





export basket recorded a single-digit decline, largely due to the impact of higher US tariffs. Industry expectations suggest that the first half of 2026 will reflect similar caution, before broader recovery sets in.

A Broader Export Canvas

Yet, 2025 also marked a structural shift. India's export footprint widened meaningfully beyond its traditional markets. Latin America emerged as a promising frontier, with Brazil showing rising interest in lightweight and plain gold jewellery. In Southeast Asia, markets such as Vietnam, Cambodia, Myanmar, and Thailand demonstrated growing appetite for gemstone-led and lightweight designs. The Middle East, one of India's most dependable corridors, continued to deliver stable demand across categories.

This geographic rebalancing has been supported by sustained outreach under the 'Brand India' banner, led by the Gem & Jewellery Export Promotion Council (GJEPC). Buyer-seller meets, India Pavilions at global exhibitions, India Design Galleries, and Experience Lounges have helped deepen engagement with new markets. At the centre of this effort remains IIJS Bharat, now the world's second-largest gem and jewellery trade fair, serving as a critical platform for business generation and market discovery.

The successful debut of the Saudi Arabia Jewellery Exposition (SAJEX) in Jeddah further strengthened India's presence in the Gulf. Combined with tourism growth, the international expansion of Indian jewellery retail chains, and tariff benefits under the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), plain gold jewellery exports to the UAE rose nearly 44 percent during April–November 2025. Diamond-studded jewellery, too, is gaining visibility in the region's luxury retail landscape.

This diversification is essential to India's long-term ambition of achieving $100 billion in gem and jewellery exports by 2047.

Policy as an Enabler

The policy environment is increasingly aligned with this ambition. Free trade agreements with the UAE, Australia, EFTA nations, and the UK have enhanced India's competitiveness, particularly in high-value jewellery segments. Proposed agreements with the European Union and, eventually, the United States could further reshape demand dynamics in studded and premium categories, where duty structures significantly influence consumer behaviour.

Digital enablers such as the Trade Connect Portal are also streamlining market access by connecting Indian exporters with verified global buyers and simplifying early-stage outreach. In November 2025, the launch of the Export Promotion Mission (EPM) added further momentum. By expanding access to affordable credit and improving market development support, the EPM directly addresses the needs of MSMEs, which constitute over 80 percent of the sector.

Redefining the Industry Landscape

While diamonds continue to adjust to softer global demand and price mismatches between rough and polished stones, jewellery exports have emerged as a stabilising force. Gold jewellery exports rose 10 percent during April–November 2025, with plain gold jewellery growing 15 percent. Studded jewellery increased by 7 percent, polished synthetic stones surged 32 percent, and platinum jewellery recorded a robust 38 percent growth. These figures underscore India's growing strength across categories, beyond its traditional diamond dominance.

Retail-led growth has also played a defining role. Indian jewellery brands such as Tanishq and Kalyan have expanded aggressively, both domestically and overseas, adding consistency to manufacturing cycles and demand visibility. India's $85 billion domestic jewellery market remains a critical second pillar of stability. With GDP growth projected at 6.7 percent for both 2025 and 2026, organised retail expansion and steady consumer demand continue to anchor the sector.

Innovation is now firmly in focus. Initiatives such as InCent–LGD, developed in collaboration with the Government of India and IIT Madras, aim to strengthen domestic R&D in lab-grown diamonds. JewelStart, India's first dedicated gems and jewellery start-up incubator, reflects a broader push toward technology, design innovation, and supply-chain solutions.

At the category level, promotion remains critical. Diamond demand is being supported by GJEPC globally through generic category efforts with market leaders like De Beers in India and Chow Tai Fook in China, while gold continues to benefit from sustained consumer education and promotion in collaboration with the World Gold Council. These initiatives feed directly into India's manufacturing and export engine.

A Disciplined Optimism

Looking ahead, the industry approaches 2026 with measured confidence. Early months may continue to reflect caution, but the foundations are stronger with a diversified export map, expanding trade access, a resilient domestic market, and a more coordinated export support ecosystem.

As **Kirit Bhansali, Chairman, GJEPC,** notes, the sector's focus is clear: widening India's export footprint, strengthening presence in established markets, and building long-term competitiveness through innovation and responsible growth. With closer collaboration between industry and government, India's gem and jewellery sector is positioned not merely to ride the next global upcycle, but to shape it with greater resilience and strategic intent.